REP-034 · Speciality price cut: Cold Room $4, Juice Bar $3

Game	Fruit Market (rules version 4)
Report date	2026-10-27 16:20 (Asia/Kuala_Lumpur)
Type	Balance change with a same-seed comparison
Plan	PLAN-016, approved: "approve the speciality price cut"
Branch	`workflow/plan-016`, merged to `main` for the preview. **Live game unchanged**

Labels. [Sim] = computer players, 300 games per test, the same seeds as REP-033, about ±5 points.

1. Change

- Cold Room: $5 → **$4**.
- Juice Bar: $4 → **$3**.
- Updated in the engine and `RULES.md`. The screens read the cost from the engine.
- `RULES_VERSION` stays 4. Version 4 has never been published to the live game, so no live player or saved score is affected. The preview's version-4 daily scores are test data.

2. Same-seed comparison [Sim]

Measure (3 players unless noted)	Before (REP-033)	After
Rush Cold Room	13%	12%
Rush Juice Bar	17%	16%
Rush Barrow / Premium Display	29% / 27%	27% / 25%
Never build a speciality	19%	16%
Juice Bar built per player (2 players)	0.14	0.06
Hard beats Normal (2 players)	56%	56%
Hard beats Easy (2 players)	63%	66%
Traits (range)	30–38%	31–40% (Big Basket 40%)
Comeback from last at half-time	31%	28%
Close games (10 days)	21%	21%

All differences are within the margin.

3. Finding

The price was not the problem. Cheaper Cold Room and Juice Bar did not help the computers win with them.

- Supply is tight in rules version 4. The computers sell almost everything while it's fresh, and spoilage is near zero (REP-033). So the Juice Bar has little old fruit to work with, and holding stock in a Cold Room rarely pays.
- These two specialities reward plans the computers don't play: buying cheap old fruit on purpose, and holding stock for a Market Day.
- [Hyp] People may use them better. The cheaper prices make them easier to try in the playtest.

4. Validation

Check	Result	Evidence
Same-seed balance comparison (PLAN-016 T1)	PASS	No figure worse by more than the margin (section 2)
`npm run verify`	PASS	Local run before merge
CI `verify:full` on `main`	Reported after the push	GitHub Actions CI

5. Options (need your decision; nothing changed yet)

1. **Keep as is and playtest.** Recommended: see whether people use Cold Room and Juice Bar before more tuning.
2. Teach the computers to plan for Market Days and to buy cheap old fruit (computer-player work, no rule change).
3. Give Juice Bar more to work with, for example +1 supply per listed fruit (a balance change; needs a plan).